

AFRICA

Conflicts and pressure are accelerating the decline of press freedom

Press freedom has never been so strained in sub-Saharan Africa, a region battered by political instability, from the [Great Lakes](#) to the [Sahel](#) to [Sudan](#). Wars, the criminalisation of journalism and economic challenges are the catalysts of this decline.

The state of press freedom is "difficult" in 24 of the region's 48 countries, and "very serious" in five: **Rwanda** (which ranks 139th out of 180 countries and territories), **Ethiopia** (148th), **Sudan** (161st), **Djibouti** (167th) and **Eritrea** (180th), the lowest-scoring country in the entire Index for the third year in a row due to its vehement denial of citizens' right to be informed. 2026 marks the 25th anniversary of the arbitrary detention of the [world's longest-detained journalist](#), Dawit Isaak, held in **Eritrea** with his three colleagues, Temesgen Ghebreyesus, Seyoum Tsehaye and Amanuel Asrat.

Flourish is disabled.

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The criminalisation of journalism

There is a clear trend of national security and cybersecurity laws being [weaponised](#) against journalists. This is because juntas in Sahel states have shrunk civic space and twisted the laws, notably in **Niger** (120th, which fell -37 spots), the country with the steepest drop in the 2026 Index. The rankings of **Mali** (121st, -2) and **Burkina Faso** (110th, -5) continue to fall, reflecting increasingly coordinated repression of the press in the countries of the Alliance of Sahel States (AES), where military regimes arbitrarily detain journalists on charges such as "spreading false information," "undermining national credibility," or "disseminating reports that could disturb public order." At least five reporters are detained in **Niger**, one in **Mali**, and two — [Serge Oulon](#) and [Moussa Sareba](#) — remain missing in **Burkina Faso**. This is compounded by the authorities' suspensions of media outlets as they try to control the press' narratives.

Benin, which usually ranks in the middle of the Index, fell this year (113th; -21). This downturn is a warning sign in a country that just elected a new president, and the previous authorities had the founder of the online media *Olofofo*, Hugues Comlan Sossoukpè, [abducted](#) and "extradited" from the **Ivory Coast** (54th) so they could throw the "dangerous cyberactivist who advocates terrorism" behind bars.

Journalists are also regularly jailed in the Great Lakes region under the pretext of national security charges, as in the case of Stanis Bujakera in the **Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC)** (130th), and Floriane Irangabiye and several journalists from the outlet *Iwacu* in **Burundi**. In **Rwanda**, two media professionals are currently detained, including Théoneste Nsengimana, on charges of "inciting unrest."

Once a leader of press freedom in the region, **Tanzania** has dropped 22 places (117th), confirming a [deterioration](#) in journalists' working conditions and access to information as legislation becomes increasingly restrictive. In better news, in **Burundi** (110th), [Serge Oulon](#) and [Moussa Sareba](#) remain missing in **Burkina Faso**. This is compounded by the authorities' suspensions of media outlets as they try to control the press' narratives.

Persistent security and economic woes

Conflict-ridden countries such as the **DRC** have seen their security indicator (27.3 out of 100) [decline](#). In the east of the country, journalists caught between armed groups and the Armed Forces of the Democratic Republic of the Congo (FARDC) are forced to flee the region or go into exile. The war in **Sudan** (161st) has all but wiped out independent journalism. For the past three years, journalists faced with the risks of arrest and [torture](#) have had no choice but to leave the country. **Ethiopia**, meanwhile, has not loosened its grip on the press, using security issues as justification.

The economic fragility of the media market, already highlighted last year, remains a major problem. In the Sahel region, **Mauritania** (61st, -11) has seen its ranking fall despite government commitments to the right to information, notably due to delays in implementing the reforms needed to protect the sector and its financial precarity. Conversely, despite a difficult socio-economic context, **Ghana** (39th, +13) and **South Africa** (21st, 6+), which top the regional ranking, fall into the "satisfactory" category for press freedom.